

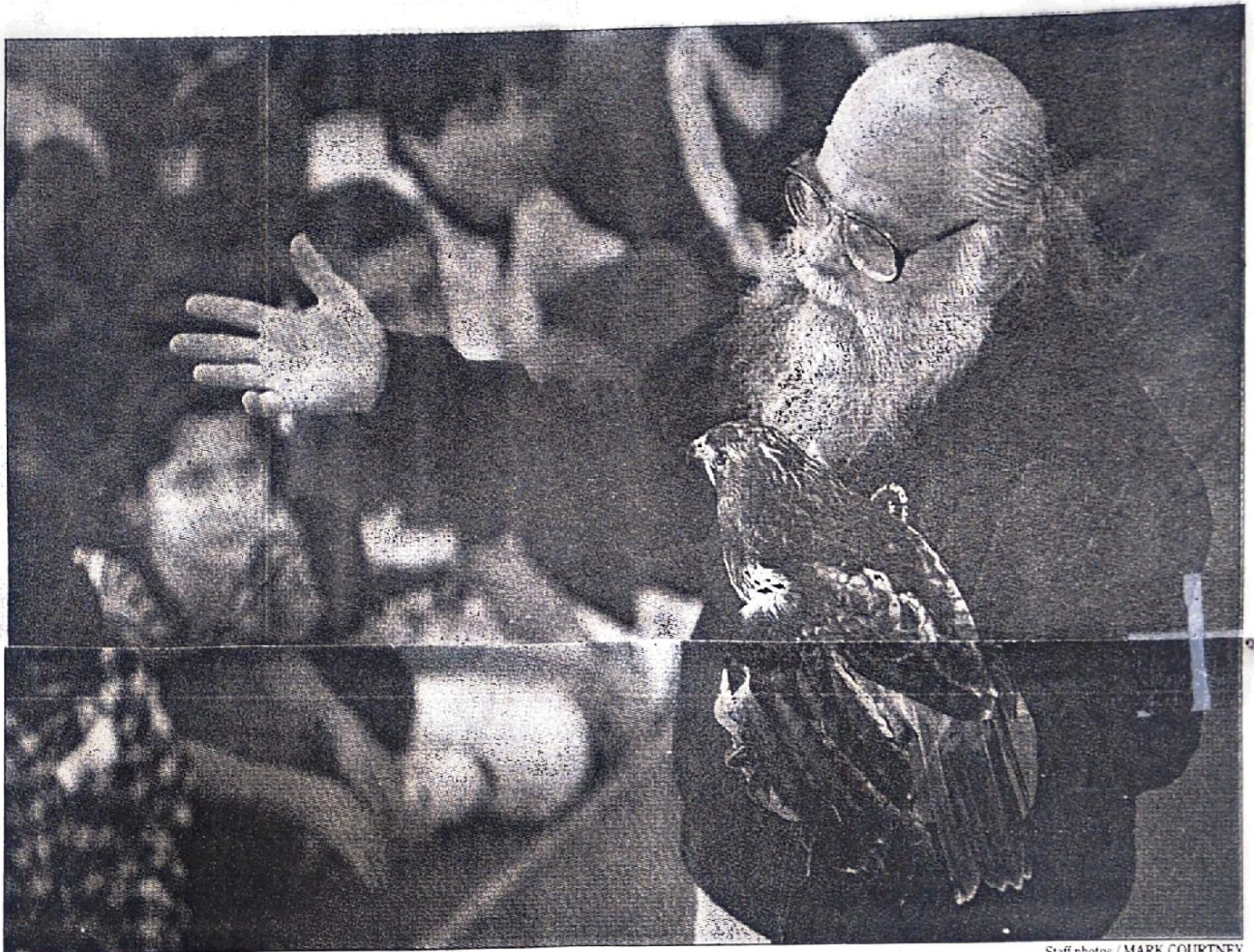
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LESSONS from the WILD



Dudley the great horned owl



Staff photos / MARK COURTNEY

Tom Rouse, from the Carolina Raptor Center in Charlotte, introduces Gregory Elementary School fourth-graders to Oliver, a red-tailed hawk that suffered damage from a gunshot.

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Raptors pay visit to area schoolchildren

By STACEY HIRSH

Staff Writer

From the floor of their school gymnasium on Wednesday, students at Gregory Elementary School made the acquaintance of a red-tailed hawk named Oliver. They also met three owls, Dudley, Lelia and Rebecca, and an American kestrel by the name of Marty.

But these weren't just any birds.

The wild animals, each of them injured in some way, had been transported from Charlotte to Wilmington to teach the students about preserving the environment.

"They soar over an open field to spot their prey. They're so beautiful when they soar, but they make an easy target," said Tom Rouse of the Carolina Raptor Center.

Mr. Rouse is visiting three schools in Wilmington this week with birds of prey from the Carolina Raptor Center, a non-profit center for conservation, education and research.

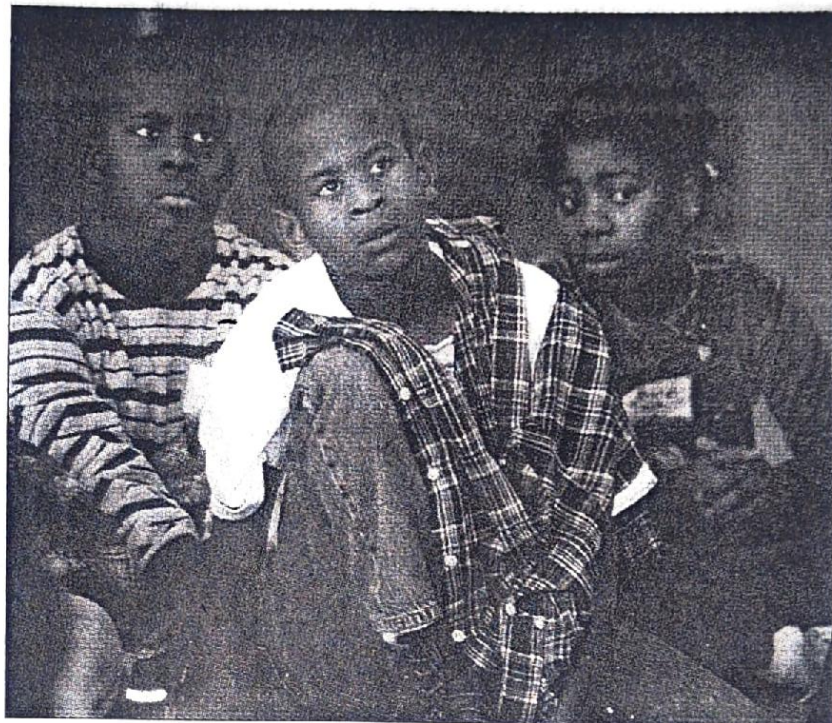
In 1998, the Carolina Raptor Center collected 577 birds of prey that had been injured, orphaned or were dead. Excluding those that died within their first 24 hours at the center, 63 percent of the birds were released into the wild. Others stayed at the Raptor Center or went on the road to educate students.

Today, some of those birds will visit Bradley Creek Elementary with Mr. Rouse. On Tuesday, they visited Williston Middle School and on Wednesday they were at Gregory, bringing with them lessons from the wild.

"What I think the children gain from this is a real personal understanding of our environment and what we have to do individually to save it," said Sandy West, a science teacher at Gregory.

And each bird that came to Gregory on Wednesday brought with it a story to that effect.

The red-tailed hawk Oliver, for instance, had been shot. Shooting a hawk is



Gregory Elementary School fourth-graders watch a bird from the Carolina Raptor Center in Charlotte. Tom Rouse was in town to give students a look at live birds of prey. The birds from the center were found injured or ill in the wild. 'I think it's a shame that people are killing birds,' said Gregory fourth-grader LaShana Farrow.

illegal. It's also the most common injury for hawks, Mr. Rouse said.

"I think it's a shame that people are killing birds, because they really don't have a reason to kill the birds," said Gregory fourth-grader LaShana Farrow.

Dudley, the great horned owl, had been imprinted by humans. Humans illegally had Dudley and were feeding him, and now he doesn't know how to hunt for himself or survive in the wild.

Liela, a barred owl, and Rebecca, an eastern screech owl, were both hit by cars.

"The reason she was in the road is

because her food was in the road, and the reason her food was in the road is because people litter," Mr. Rouse said of Rebecca.

Being hit by a car is a common injury for owls as they swoop down to catch mice feeding on litter in the road.

"I'm telling you it is not OK," Mr. Rouse said. "Do not throw out anything, because animals are being hurt."

Gregory fourth-grader Catherine Stukes agreed: "You shouldn't litter because when you do the birds will go fly to your litter and try to eat it, and people may run into the birds."